

fridayReview

THE HINDU

Interesting interpretation
A new Kathakali production ‘Mandodari’ stands out for its unique portrayals **p2**

Reaching out through art
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PUPPETS NARRATE AN ICONIC PAINTER’S LIFE

The Ishaara Puppet Theatre’s new work traces Amrita Sher-Gil’s journey **p4**

How A.R. Rahman is reimagining himself for the stage with his sufiyana vision and love for the classical tradition

The showman and the sound



Jyoti Nair

The loud cheer from the Chennai crowd at A.R. Rahman’s concert on February 14, as part of his Wonderment Tour, echoed through the cool night sky. It was a dazzling fusion of lights, beats and hit melodies. Celebrated for redefining Indian cinema music on the world stage, in the past few months, Rahman has transformed into a performer who loves to engage with different genres of music. The highlight of this engagement is his ability to preserve the authenticity of diverse styles yet make them appealing for a contemporary listeners.

Audiences in Mumbai and Delhi witnessed this recently as the Oscar-winning composer delved deep into classical ragas and sufi mysticism. The shows wove together his musical and spiritual thoughts. In doing so, Rahman reiterated that the future of culture lies not in reinvention alone, but in thoughtful continuity – where beauty, discipline and meaning endure across generations.

The highlight of the Delhi performance was JHALAA, an ensemble of 12 young classically trained artistes, mentored by Rahman. They were selected through a global talent search. Its repertoire spans compositions by legends such as Ustad Bade Ghulam Ali Khan, Oothukkadu Venkata Subbaiyer,

Ustad Ghulam Mustafa Khan, Pt. Laxmanprasad Jaipurwale, Kunwar Shyam Ji and Amir Khusrau. It also includes compositions by Munna Shoakath Ali and Rahman.

The performance unfolded as a carefully structured journey through sound and movement. It began with a bandish in raag Bhatiyar, a morning raag, which belongs to the Marwa thaata. A favourite of Rahman, it was delineated beautifully enveloping the whole place with its movement in vakr – sa dha, pa, dha, ma, pa, ga, ma, dha, sa; in aroha re; in komal touching tivri ni – creating a stir, as the alaps and the taans overlapped harmoniously.

The evening also featured songs such as ‘Aao balma’ in raag Yaman Kalyan, ‘Bhor bhayi’ in raag Gurjari Todi and Carnatic compositions like ‘Alaipayude’. Classical dance forms, including Kathak, Bharatanatyam and Kuchipudi were seamlessly interwoven, most strikingly in ‘Aigiri Nandini’, where the trishul became a visual invocation to Devi.

During its presentation, JHALAA also brought alive the Navarasas – the nine essential emotions of Indian aesthetics – with clarity and restraint.



Introduced on several occasions by Rahman himself, and at other performances by Sai Shravanam, JHALAA stands as a collective rather than a display of individual virtuosity. Its growing journey across India and the world seems to reflect a deeper purpose: to reaffirm Indian classical music and dance as living traditions. This also spotlighted a different dimension of Rahman’s musical sensibilities.

The band is Rahman’s effort to preserve the musical memories of classical maestros by taking it to the next generation. In interviews after the performance, he said he was deeply humbled by the audience’s response, noting how it reflected the unifying power of art. Throughout this show, there were no requests from the audience for film songs.

Complementing Rahman’s classical work is another profound cultural offering – his Sufiyana vision. In his global articulation of Sufi philosophy as a universal human path, he draws inspiration from Sufi saints and mystic poets across regions and centuries. Though it came through clearly in this concert, this philosophy has always defined Rahman’s music.

What also stood out at his recent presentations in Mumbai and Delhi was Haazri, conceived as a tribute to Rahman’s guru Ustad Ghulam Mustafa Khan. The performance brought together some of India’s most respected voices including Sonu Nigam, Hariharan and Shaan, who joined in honouring a lineage that has shaped generations of music-making.

The Ustad along with his sons had collaborated with Rahman for ‘Aao balma’ (a Coke Studio-MTV song). An exponent of Rampur-Sahaswan gharana, Ustad Ghulam Mustafa Khan mentored many renowned musicians. Apart from performing classical concerts, the Ustad had also sung in films.

The repertoire opened with ‘Ik Onkar’ from the *Guru Granth Sahib*, a contemplative invocation, reflecting the elusive yet all-pervading presence of the divine. It then journeyed effortlessly through some of Rahman’s most transcendent compositions including ‘Khawaja mere khawaja’, ‘Kun faya kun’, ‘Piya haji ali’, and ‘Deewana deewana’ (one of his recent works), before moving into traditional Sufi offerings that have echoed across centuries.

Pieces such as ‘Tu kuja mann kuja’, ‘Dum mast qalandar,’ and ‘Phool khile bagiyann mein’ unfolded with meditative grace, culminating in Rahman’s new composition ‘Ladle farid ke, peere Nizamuddin’, set in raag Basant Bahar.

From the studio to the stage, from film music to sufiana *kalaams*, Rahman shows how music is an ever-widening horizon, one that he constantly chases.

Widening musical arc A.R. Rahman and the 12-member Jhalaa ensemble mentored by him. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

CULTUREBRIEFS



Creative steps

Bharata Kalanjali presents the fifth edition of Jharna at the TEACH Auditorium, SPASTN, Taramani. Apart from performances by senior dancers, four young dancers will premiere their original works. The curtains will go up with Sahana Selvaganesh’s ‘Tied: The Weaver’s Loom’ (Feb. 21, 7 p.m.), a solo performance that uses weaving as a metaphor to trace a woman’s journey from emotional constraints to finding inner strength. This will be followed by ‘The Abandoned Gopi’ by Himanshu Srivastava (8 p.m.). On February 22, 7 p.m.: Kruthika Thyagarajan’s performance will be followed by ‘Pinnal’, a presentation by Dakshina Repertory, directed by Divya Nayar (8 p.m.). On February 28 (7 p.m.) Navyashree K.N. performance will be followed ‘In other words’ (8 p.m.) directed by Bhavya Balantrapu. The festival will conclude on March 1, 7 p.m.: with Vaishnavai Dhore performance followed by ‘Vrajam Bhaje’ (8 p.m.) by Renjith and Vijna.



Rhythm legacy

Mridangam maestro Umayalpuram K. Sivaraman’s Laya Laavanyaa Fine Arts Foundation’s annual event will be held on February 21 at Narada Gana Sabha Main Hall. It will begin at 5.15 p.m. with Thevara Isai by the students of Sri Kanchi Kamakoti Peetam Veda Siva Agama Patasala, followed by Sama Vedam recitation (6 p.m.) and Dushyanth Sridhar’s discourse ‘Nandhipura vinnagaram nannu maname’. Nalli Kuppuswami Chetti will be the chief guest and Kumar Vembu, the guest of honour. On the occasion, the foundation will honour Revathi Sankaran, Dushyanth Sridhar, T. Ramasami and Srimushanam Rajarao.



Dedicated to a guru

Sarasalaya presents the annual festival Sarasa Natya Mala, in memory of guru K.J. Sarasa. The event, in its 14th edition, will be held on February 21 and 22, at Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan, Mylapore. ‘KJ Sarasa Memorial award’ (5.30 p.m.) will be presented to veteran vocalist Yogam Santhanam and senior Bharatanatyam dancer Urmila Sathanarayanan. The inaugural evening will feature performances by the students of Saila Sudha (4.30 p.m.); Anusuya Ghosh Banerjee (6 p.m.) and Urmila Sathanarayanan (7 p.m.). Performances on day two are by Divyatha Shekar (5 p.m.); Mahalakshmi Ashwin (6 p.m.) and Shanmuga Sundaram (7 p.m.). Dancer-scholar Nandini Ramani will be chief guest, and Dancer-choreographer Radhika Shurajit, the guest of honour.

Achuthan T.K.

There are several other interesting features. For instance, the story presents Ravana in a different light. While Ravana is usually depicted as powerful and arrogant, here he is subdued, pensive and a tad regretful.



New Kathakali plays – shorter than traditional productions – are being crafted to suit contemporary audiences, and *Mandodari* shows every sign of fitting into that evolving repertoire.

V.V. Ramani

The performance began with showcasing the mother-child bond through Bharati's verses, and moved on to depict the one with the motherland and mother tongue and Nature. The last one with Nature was explored through 'Surya Namaskar' and Muthuswami Dikshitar's Saurashtara kriti 'Suryamurthe' that extolled the Sun as the life-giving force and ended with an impressive tableaux of the sun god riding the chariot drawn by seven horses. The scenes portraying various facets of Agni, based on

All the compositions were set to tune by Rajkumar Bharathi. Group formations and patterns were choreographed to align with the ideas, but felt repetitive. Streamlining entries and exits would have enhanced the appeal. Though the individual segments were conceived well, the overarching concept of oneness didn't come through effectively. The ideation and presentation should have been woven together seamlessly.

Thematic Students of Mudralaya performing 'Aikyam'.
PHOTO: B. VELANKANNI RAJ



The sixth edition of the Dr. Maya Rao Kathak and Choreography Conference highlighted the pivotal role of women in the dance form's evolution

Shailaja Tripathi

“Post-Independence, it was women who adapted Kathak from the *gharanedars* and male dancers and carried it to different cities. Today, the cities where the *gharanas* originated are no longer major



Kathak hubs. Many *gharanedars* moved to Pune, Bengaluru, Delhi and Mumbai to work in institutions established by women such as scholars Kapila Vatsyayan and Nirmala Joshi, and patrons such as Sumitira Charat Ram,” said dancer-researcher Siddhi Goel in her talk, *Women in Kathak: Architects of Modernity*.



A dance form's journey
(Clockwise from left) Maya Rao; Siddhi Goel; Madhu Nataraj; and Kumudini Lakhia PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



“Maya Rao,” said Chiranjiv Singh, former director, Information, Culture and Tourism, Government of Karnataka, “was responsible for creating the Kathak ecosystem in Bengaluru. She was not only a dancer, but a visionary, who brought a fresh approach to teaching and choreography.”

It was at the behest of Kamaladevi

Chattopadhyay that Maya Rao launched NIKC – said to be the first major institution of Kathak in South India, where she trained several students. She also choreographed landmark productions including 'Amir Khuro', 'Venkateshwara Vilasam', 'Kathak through the Ages, Art and Life' and 'Surdas'. Chiranjiv Singh requested Madhu Nataraj to

In 1964, Kumudini Lakhia founded the Kadamb Centre for Dance in Ahmedabad, where she mentored several noted dancers, including Daksha Sheth and Aditi Mangaldas.

initially forbidden by her parents from performing publicly. She went on to become one of the finest Kathak teachers of her time. She developed a pioneering methodology to train physically handicapped children and also designed the Diploma (Hons) curriculum for Kathak Kendra.

“Reba ji had extraordinary depth in her craft, but very little is known about her. There isn’t a single video of her in the public domain because she never performed publicly, though a few recordings exist in the Sangeet Natak Akademi archives,” said Siddhi.



A string of experiments

Ishara Puppet Theatre, which is reinventing puppetry for modern audiences, will premiere its new production based on iconic artist Amrita Sher-Gil's life



Neha Kirpal

Europe belongs to Picasso, Matisse, Braque, and many others. India belongs only to me,” – these lines by one of India’s visionary artists, Amrita Sher-Gil, embody her enigmatic life. Born in Budapest in 1913, she lived across Europe until her untimely death in Lahore at the age of 28. Her words were not mere bravado, but the distilled truth of a life lived at the crossroads of continents and cultures. A new play, by Ishara Puppet Theatre, brings Amrita Sher-Gil’s life to the stage. She defied conventions and challenges and

became one of the most influential figures in global art. Through vibrant puppetry, kaleidoscopic sets, video projection, classical music and emotional storytelling, the production celebrates her legacy. Designed and directed by Dadi D. Pudumjee and performed by Ishara Puppet Theatre – the 60-minute production in English – narrates her tale through puppetry for the very first time. It is based on a project undertaken by five art students, who bring alive her life story through paintings, letters and biographical accounts. Each year, the Ishara Puppet Theatre and group create a new performance, some for children, others for young adults and

mature audiences. “After our play, *Be Yourself*, I found myself drawn towards a theme around art. That search naturally led me to Amrita Sher-Gil. Many people know her iconic paintings and her short, dramatic life, but once we delved deeper we realised there was much more to showcase,” says Pudumjee, a puppeteer and founder of The Ishara Puppet Theatre Trust. The foundation of the play’s research lay in Amrita’s letters to her friends and family, which unravel her intellect, wit, vulnerability and fierce independence. “We also drew from documented biographies, archival photographs and critical studies of her paintings. Rather than simply presenting facts, we

When puppets speak (Left) From Ishara's new work Amrita Sher-Gil: A Life Lived. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



immersed ourselves in her voice – her doubts, confidence and her sense of destiny. Her correspondence forms the emotional spine of the play. The research phase was deeply engaging, allowing us to move beyond the myth and into the lived experience of a young woman – negotiating identity, culture and artistic ambition,” shares Pudumjee. The scholarly writings of Yashodhara Dalmia and the archival compilations by her nephew Vivan Sundaram were invaluable. “Vivan’s volumes, in particular, provide intimate access to Amrita’s letters, photographs and personal reflections. We were also inspired by accounts from relatives – in Hungary and India – which offered a cross-cultural perspective of her life. These sources helped us understand

not only her artistic development but also the emotional and geographical worlds she inhabited. The play does not replicate these material directly, but they informed the texture and authenticity of our interpretation,” says Pudumjee. It may have started as a passing idea, but the play took shape from one of Amrita’s black-and-white images displayed at a café in Paris, where she is speaking with fellow students. Actors, puppeteers, designers, and musicians shaped it further from an image in a café. From this emerged the concept the five art students worked on. “For the first time an Ishara production combines actors with naturalistic puppets in a more integrated manner.” Music plays a vital role in Ishara’s productions. “It carries emotional transitions and atmospheres beyond words. The costume, sculpture, light and movement add layers to the storytelling. Theatre is never a solitary act, it is a shared act of imagination between artistes and dreamers working toward a single vision. For me, theatre must always push boundaries, just as Amrita did,” says Pudumjee.

Amrita Sher-Gil: A Life Lived premieres on February 22, 4 p.m. and 7.30 p.m. at Stein Auditorium, India Habitat Centre, New Delhi.



Rather than simply presenting facts, we immersed ourselves in her voice – her doubts, confidence and her sense of destiny.

DADI D. PUDUMJEE

Between freedom and faith

Feroz Abbas Khan’s *Hind 1957*, an adaptation of August Wilson’s *Fences*, revisits the unhealed wounds of Partition

Anuj Kumar

Expressing the unspoken, Feroz Abbas Khan’s *Hind 1957* makes us reflect on our humanity. Staged at the Bharat Rang Mahotsav, the play is about a Muslim family that chooses to remain in India post-Partition. It is a sensitive and thoughtful Hindustani adaptation of August Wilson’s Pulitzer Prize-winning play *Fences* (1985), by Vikas Bahari. The play transposes the 1950s African-American experience in Pittsburgh to the Muslim narrative in post-Partition India. Spread over two acts, the play explores themes of patriarchy, prejudice, family secrets and the tension between a weary father’s cynicism and the optimism of his sons for a better future. The poignant story makes you realise that classics don’t age. The central character, Tabrez Ansari (evocatively portrayed by Sachin Khedekar), is a poet who participated in the freedom movement. He is wrongfully imprisoned after his father migrates to Pakistan and is tired of being repeatedly interrogated by the police. He works in a bidi factory to keep the home fires burning. Charged as a spy, Tabrez personifies the shattered dreams of a generation, poignantly captured towards the end



Poignant Sachin Khedekar and Sonal Jha in the play and (below) Feroz Abbas Khan. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

through Abhishek Shukla’s verse, ‘Main ghar kahoon toh Hindustan samajh samjha jaye....’ Feroz resists generalising the Muslim peeve or romanticising the laments of progressive writers. Tabrez is flawed in his understanding of society and family, and uses religion opportunistically. His poetry is progressive, but his behaviour within the four walls is far from forward-looking. For him, drinking liquor is being liberal, but when it comes to infidelity, he invokes the Shariat. He uses his brother’s pension to have a roof over his family’s head.

Tabrez tries to pass on his bitterness to his sons, who, in a departure from the traditional depiction of Muslim families, embrace India with all its imperfections. They are not chained by their

Within its layers, the play holds tales of everyday discrimination that continue to bog us down as a society



father’s fears. Latif takes to his father’s poetic legacy while Kaif wears his love for the nation in his army uniform. They believe their father will get justice under the Indian Constitution, and the writer rewards their patience and optimism. It is not a propaganda of hope, though. Within its layers, the play holds tales of everyday

discrimination that continue to bog us down as a society. Over a shared glass of country liquor, Banwari (Dadhi R. Pandey), a close friend of Tabrez, talks of his pain when he is not allowed to touch the bidis in the factory because he is a Dalit. Perhaps, that’s why Banwari understands Tabrez’s anguish at being othered despite rejecting the communal bait of Jinnah and not following his father’s footsteps to Pakistan. Known for writing strong female characters, Feroz takes a dig at deep-seated patriarchal mores. Sachin’s understated yet powerful portrayal of the flawed patriarch binds the play together, but it is Sonal Jha who emerges as its emotional fulcrum. As Razia, she confronts Tabrez when he uses family responsibilities as a cover for philandering. She says she has given as much to the family as he has, but she doesn’t have the option to grow tired of the relationship. The emotional showdown between Tabrez and Razia is the highlight of the play. Feroz makes generous space for tragicomic sequences like the one where Tabrez’s mentally impaired brother, Gulrez, turns up with a rose for Razia in the midst of a heated exchange spurred by Tabrez’s admission of an extramarital affair. Feroz uses Shukla’s *shayari* as a cultural bridge to convey longing, belonging and emotional depth, while the rich production design and lighting evoke a period in which broken parapets suggest fractured bonds, leaving viewers reflective in an emotional swell.

Hind 1957 will be staged on February 21 and 22 at NMACC, Mumbai.

CALENDAR



Tyagaraja aradhana Bharat Kalachar will feature the following programmes as part of Tyagaraja aradhana at YGP Auditorium, Tirumalai Road, T. Nagar. Schedule: Feb. 21, 6.30 p.m.: Gayathri Girish’s vocal concert; Feb. 22, 9.30 a.m.: Rendition of Pancharatna kritis; 4.30 p.m.: Girija Shankar Sundaresan’s vocal concert; 7.15 p.m.: ‘Ramam Manoharam Manoharam Ramam’, dance drama by the students of Sri Sai Nrithyalaya.

Thematic programme

Samunnati and Rasikapriya have jointly organised a special concert ‘A journey through languages’ by Amrutha Venkatesh on February 22, 5.30 p.m. at Hiranandani Club House, Egattur. Avaneesswaram S.R. Vinu (violin), Patri Satish Kumar (midangam) and S. Karthick (ghatam) are the accompanists.

Special concert

Students of senior violinist R.K. Shriramkumar will present a special concert featuring his compositions on February 21, 5.45 p.m. The programme, organised by Naada Inbam will be held at Ragasudha Hall, Luz, Myslapore. Sandeep Ramachandran and Madan Mohan on the violin, K. Arunprakash on the midangam and N. Guruprasad on the ghatam are the accompanists.

Kathakali solo

Mahalingapuram Sree Ayyappan Guruvavayurappan Temple and V4U jointly present ‘Onnu Chirikk, Orukkil Koodi’ (Smile For Me, Once More), a Kathakali solo performance conceived and presented by Kalamandalam Vijayakumar (UK). The evening also features ‘Chutti’ by Kalamandalam Barbara Vijayakumar (UK). The recitals will take place on February 21, 5.45 p.m., at the Sopanam Hall of the temple.



Bharatanatyam solo

Natyanrangam, the dance wing of Narada Gana Sabha Trust, has organised the following Bharatanatyam performances on February 21 at its mini hall. Schedule: Aditi Arunkumar (6 p.m.) followed by Anjali Viswesh (7.30 p.m.).

Annual festival

Hamsadhwani, as part of its 36th annual festival, will feature the following performances at Youth Hostel, Adyar. Details: Today, 6.15 p.m.: Brinda Manickavasakan. February 21, 6.15 p.m.: Palghat Ramprasad. February 22, 6.15 p.m.: Ashwath Narayan. February 26, 5.15 p.m.: Rendering of Pancharatna kritis, as part of Tyagaraja aradhana, organised jointly with International Association of Lions Club - District 324-1 B.

Musical homage to Tirtha

Thirupoonthuruthy Sri Narayana Tirtha Swamigal Trust has organised a three-day programme on the occasion of the 280th aradhana of Narayana Tirtha from February 22 to 24, at Thirupoonthuruthy village, Thanjavur. The event is organised by V. Neela and V. Lakshmi, daughters of Thirupoonthuruthy Venkatesan. The programmes will include music concerts, namasankirtanam themed on Krishna Leela Tarangini, composed by Narayana Tirtha, Tirumurai rendition and discourses. The Tirtha aradhana will be performed on February 24.



Echoes of Beethoven

Anand Seshadri, a pianist and composer based in Chennai, will perform a lecture-recital featuring the compositions by Brahms, Schubert, Beethoven and his own works on February 21, at The Museum Theatre, Egmore. Anandhad undertaken the ‘Beethoven 32’ project, to perform and record the complete list of Ludwig van Beethoven’s Piano Sonatas. He will present the first recital of this series, featuring [Appassionata] alongside his own original compositions.